your life. What's more, a qualified professional can ensure that you benefit from and comply with the staggering complexity of the tax laws and retirement rules.

Trust, then Verify

Remember that financial con artists thrive by talking you into trusting them and by talking you out of investigating them. Before you place your financial future in the hands of an adviser, it's imperative that you find someone who not only makes you comfortable but whose honesty is beyond reproach. As Ronald Reagan used to say, "Trust, then verify." Start off by thinking of the handful of people you know best and trust the most. Then ask if they can refer you to an adviser whom *they* trust and who, they feel, delivers good value for his fees. A vote of confidence from someone you admire is a good start.[2]

Once you have the name of the adviser and his firm, as well as his specialty—is he a stockbroker? financial planner? accountant? insurance agent?—you can begin your due diligence. Enter the name of the adviser and his or her firm into an Internet search engine like Google to see if anything comes up (watch for terms like "fine," "complaint," "lawsuit," "disciplinary action," or "suspension"). If the adviser is a stockbroker or insurance agent, contact the office of your state's securities commissioner (a convenient directory of online links is at www.nasaa.org) to ask whether any disciplinary actions or customer complaints have been filed against the adviser.[3] If you're considering an accountant who also functions as a financial adviser, your state's accounting regulators (whom you can find through the National Association of State Boards of Accountancy at www.nasba.org) will tell you whether his or her record is clean.

Financial planners (or their firms) must register with either the U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission or securities regulators in the state where their practice is based. As part of that registration, the adviser must file a two-part document called Form ADV. You should be able to view and download it at www.advisorinfo.sec.gov, www.iard. com, or the website of your state securities regulator. Pay special attention to the Disclosure Reporting Pages, where the adviser must disclose any disciplinary actions